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HUM-375 Critical Theory

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Internalizing Alienation

When I first encountered the concept of alienation, it was hard to relate to it and really understand the crux of it. Marx's 19th-century factory worker dilemma seemed irrelevant to me, as I am not blue-collar. Instead, I chose engineering, focusing on problem-solving, which makes my work vary daily. I experience greater variety within my discipline and am not subjected to stereotypical, repetitive labor under overt coercion.

The reading prompted me to reconsider what alienation means on a personal level, particularly in relation to my own experience as a student. The reading defines alienation as "humans being separated, estranged, or distanced from something crucial to their freedom or capacity to flourish," which I found understandable. However, the assertion that "[o]ne is alienated when one has a distorted or deficient relation to oneself or to the natural or social world" unsettled me. Instead of focusing on industrial exploitation, I concentrated on the notion of a distorted relation to oneself, which provoked feelings of insecurity. Marx describes alienation as workers producing a vast amount of goods that they cannot effectively access or control. Their labor becomes something "over which they have no control." Their livelihoods turn into commodities that confront them as external forces. From my perspective, I experience something different, not as explicitly exploitative. I control my classes, choose my internships, and set my own goals. However, I feel that the product I am constantly manufacturing is myself. The simple act of completing tasks, including this assignment, builds a portfolio-self. My academic-related accomplishments, internships, and measurable progress form part of something that can be displayed and evaluated. In that sense, I do not feel alienated from my labor itself. However, I do feel that the work I show and explain is constantly optimized to fit what society expects of me. I sometimes feel alienated from the hyper-optimized version of myself that my labor produces.

The reading discusses how theorists such as Rahel Jaeggi reinterpret alienation not as the loss of a fixed human essence but as a failure in self-relation. Jaeggi's conception of alienation as a "relation of relationlessness" where one fails to adequately appropriate oneself or the world directly relates to my experiences. For instance, her emphasis on the difficulty of appropriating one's life resonates with the way I often view myself less as someone simply living and more as a project to manage. In this context, the standards by which I measure adequacy, such as tracking protein intake, timing commutes for efficiency, and centering my schedule around productivity, become forms of self-relation organized by

external or abstract criteria. While these behaviors reflect discipline and ambition, they also exemplify the risk Jaeggi identifies in relating to oneself primarily through evaluative or managerial metrics. My relationship to myself sometimes resembles employment, where I act as a manager of my own performance rather than as an integrated individual. I often find it difficult to avoid translating that expression into measurable outputs, which aligns with Jaeggi's argument that alienation arises when self-relation is mediated by impersonal or external frameworks rather than authentic self-appropriation. The reading proposes that alienation involves not only external domination but also the way human-produced entities can be “wrongly taken by them as something given or outside their conscious control.” I sometimes experience my own standards in this manner. The expectation to continuously improve, refine, or educate myself often seems shaped by social media and broader cultural pressures. It feels as though I have internalized an evaluative system that now governs me. When I achieve a goal, such as securing a new internship or making measurable fitness progress, the satisfaction is fleeting and quickly replaced by the next milestone. The form of myself I strive to build remains slightly ahead, and I am perpetually attempting to catch up.

Hartmut Rosa's concept of “resonance” also interested me. He contrasts alienation with a “vibrant or responsive relation to the world” and describes alienation as experiencing the world as “ossified, mute, or hostile.” I sometimes feel this resonance. When I am solving a problem, the problem fights back, usually with another problem, and then I respond again; there is a sense of mutual engagement. However, when I approach tasks primarily as a means to produce measurable results, the world appears instrumental. I am not in dialogue with it; I am extracting value from it. I can also see how I sometimes treat my abilities, interests, and even relationships strategically, fitting myself into an outside model of success.

This experience is difficult to describe because it does not fit the traditional definition of oppression. As the reading notes state, alienation is a social pathology rather than an individual defect. My stress is not attributable to personality or genetics but to being embedded in a culture that promotes constant self-optimization. The modern ideal emphasizes active self-management over passive conformity. For example, I often find myself meticulously updating my resume and LinkedIn profile to showcase every minor accomplishment, driven by the pressure to be a more competitive job candidate. We are encouraged to be autonomous and entrepreneurial, particularly as seniors in engineering school. Within this context, alienation assumes a subtler form. It is not that my labor is taken from me; rather, I increasingly perceive myself in terms of marketability and performance, reminiscent of the experience of applying to colleges and essentially “selling myself.”

At the same time, the idea of becoming a completely “authentic self” feels unrealistic to me. I value structured growth. The reading cautions against relying on “substantive conceptions of human nature” to define what non-alienation should look like. I cannot assume that there is a pure version of myself covered beneath social influences. Instead, what seems most important is the quality of my relationship to my goals. Do I pursue them because they authentically resonate with me, or because I have absorbed external standards so deeply that they feel indistinguishable from my own interests?

In class, we discuss emancipation as negation, a dialectical process challenging the powers that shape us. For me, emancipation may involve questioning the degree to which I base my self-worth on measurable achievements. This does not imply abandoning ambition or accomplishment but rather altering my relationship to my goals. Emancipation would not necessitate dismantling my entire life structure but modifying the perspective from which I engage with it.

Ultimately, this reading prompted me to recognize that contemporary alienation often manifests less through overt exploitation and more through the pervasive expectation of continual self-optimization. This shift reframes alienation as a subtle yet persistent transformation in how individuals relate to themselves, making personal growth inseparable from external standards and expectations. If, as the reading suggests, alienation is best understood as a “distorted or deficient relation to oneself,” then the challenge is not simply to reject ambition, but to critically evaluate whether my pursuit of improvement genuinely reflects my own values or is largely shaped by societal pressures. In seeing all of these insights, I am left questioning how I might cultivate a more authentic relationship with my ambitions, one that balances aspiration with self-awareness, and resists being entirely defined by standards I have not actively chosen.

Works Cited

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Grammarly was also used to polish this response paper.